6

CHINA VERSUS JAPAN

Asia's Other Great Game

> We confer upon you, therefore, the title Queen of Wa Friendly to Wei. . . . We expect you, O Queen, to rule your people in peace and to endeavor to be devoted and obedient.
>
> —Letter of Emperor Cao Rui to Japanese empress Himiko in 238 CE, *Wei zhi* (History of the Kingdom of Wei, c. 297 CE)

> From the emperor of the country where the sun rises to the emperor of the country where the sun sets.
>
> —Letter from Empress Suiko to Emperor Yang of the Sui Dynasty in 607 CE, *Nihon shoki* (Chronicles of Japan, 720 CE)

I.

The specter of the world's two strongest nations competing for power and influence has created a convenient narrative for pundits and observers to claim that Asia's future, perhaps even the world's, will be

---

This essay is adapted from "China vs. Japan: Asia's Other Great Game," *National Interest*, no. 152 (November/December 2017).